

Mailbox Restore and Hold Removal - Operator Guide

Reading, bringing back, releasing or destroying a mailbox that the cleanup preserved

This is the reverse of the Mailbox Cleanup process. Use it when something has to be done with a mailbox that is on hold or whose owner has been deleted: a manager needs to read an ex-employee's mail, a person is coming back, a hold or a deletion was a mistake, or a retention period has ended and the mailbox may now be destroyed.

The process has one triage step and then **exactly one of five paths**. Two of the five destroy something. The assistant works out which path applies from what the mailbox actually is - not from how the request was worded - and tells you which path and why before the first command.

You do not need to know PowerShell. At each step the assistant prints the exact command, you paste it into your window and paste the result back, and it checks the result before moving on.

Restore is not recover

"Restore their mailbox" means two different things, and picking the wrong one destroys evidence while you think you are helping.

- **Restore** (path 2) **copies** the mail from the preserved mailbox into a shared mailbox someone can open. The preserved copy is untouched and stays on hold. This is the answer to almost every request.
- **Recover** (path 3) **reactivates** the preserved mailbox itself. The preserved copy ceases to exist and the hold goes with it. It only works for an account that was cloud-only and was deleted more than 30 days ago - which is not most accounts here.

If a manager wants to read the mail, that is path 2. If a person is coming back and their account came from the on-premises directory (the usual case here), their mailbox comes back a different way - a new account, then path 2 to copy the old mail into it - and the preserved copy is kept. Path 3 is the exception, not the default.

Before you start

- An admin account that is an **Exchange Administrator** (or Global Administrator). Path 4 additionally needs User Administrator. You sign in three times; a browser window opens each time.
- The email address of the mailbox, and one line saying what the requester wants to happen.
- A ServiceDesk Plus ticket, or permission to open one. A ticket helps but never blocks the work: if ticketing cannot be reached, the assistant says so once and keeps the record in its closing report instead.
- For path 5 only: written authorisation naming who authorised the destruction, when, and under which retention schedule. If someone else now uses the same email address, the authorisation must also name the mailbox's own identifier (its ExchangeGuid) - see path 5. The assistant asks for the reference before it prints anything.
- **Everything this process needs is included.** There is nothing to download, install or set up first. The assistant checks what is present on your PC and, if anything is missing, asks you once - "**Shall I install these under your user profile?**" - and installs it under your own profile. Never an administrator prompt, never machine-wide.
- Two folders are created for you: **C:\scripts\reports** and **C:\scripts\logs**.

The blue window rule

Every command is pasted into a **blue Windows PowerShell window**. Open the Start menu, type **Windows PowerShell**, and open the blue icon whose title bar says **Windows PowerShell** - not PowerShell 7, and not an administrator window. Run it as yourself.

The first thing the assistant asks you to paste is **\$PSVersionTable.PSEdition**. If the window replies **Desktop**, you are in the right place. If it replies **Core**, close that window and open the blue one.

Only the returning-employee route (path 3, when the account is created on-premises) and sometimes path 4 have a step on another machine: a directory sync on the server **AWSPRDINFAAD01**. You connect with Remote Desktop, open the same kind of blue Windows PowerShell window there, paste two lines, and come back to your own PC.

Setup (steps S1 to S6)

1. **Which mailbox, and what does the requester want?** One address and one sentence.
2. **The ticket.** "Do you have a ServiceDesk Plus ticket for this, or should I open one?" It shows you the title first and waits for your yes. If ticketing is not reachable it tells you once and carries on - the record goes in the closing report.
3. **Your PC is checked and, with your permission, anything missing is installed** under your profile. Then open your blue window and confirm Desktop. The assistant asks for the one thing it cannot know: the email address you sign in to Microsoft 365 admin with. Every command after that arrives complete - nothing else is set up or typed by hand.
4. **Connect** to Exchange Online, Microsoft Graph and Purview - three sign-ins. Good looks like no red text, one mailbox row, and your account name.
5. **Your roles are checked** in the same window. Good looks like PASS for Exchange Administrator. A FAIL for eDiscovery Manager does not block restore work.
6. **The assistant confirms which role the chosen path needs** and stops here if you do not hold it, naming the role.

Step o - What state is the mailbox really in?

The preservation check reads the mailbox and reports one of four states; the state, not the wording of the request, decides the path. Result file: C:\scripts\logs\MailboxPreservation-(time).csv. Afterwards the assistant prints the reconnect lines - the check closes your connection when it finishes.

- **Active** - the account exists and nothing has been deleted. Path 1.
- **Inactive** - the account was deleted while a hold was in place, so the mailbox is preserved. Path 2 to read it. A returning person is usually also path 2 (see path 3 for why).
- **SoftDeleted** - deleted with **no** hold. It will be purged 30 days after deletion with no way back. Path 4, and the assistant tells you how many days are left in its very first reply.
- **NotFound** - purged, past 30 days, or a wrong address. The assistant checks for near-matches (first@ versus first.last@) before concluding anything. No path; escalate.

Two more facts are read at the same time and can change the path regardless of what was asked for:

- **Deleted less than 30 days ago.** Even if the mailbox shows as inactive, Microsoft does not allow it to be recovered directly inside 30 days - the account has to be restored instead. That is path 4, whatever the request said.
- **An auto-expanding archive.** A preserved mailbox that had one can be neither recovered nor copied. Its content is only reachable through a Purview eDiscovery export. The assistant says so and stops.

The assistant records the mailbox's ExchangeGuid - a long identifier - and uses it instead of the email address from then on. A preserved mailbox can share an address with a live one, and the address silently points at the wrong mailbox.

Path 1 - Remove a hold from an active mailbox (reversible)

For a hold applied by mistake, or a person who is staying. Nothing is deleted - but items already older than the retention rules become deletable within days, and the assistant says so.

1. **Record what is there now.** The assistant reads every kind of hold on the mailbox - there are four, not one - and tells you which are present. Removing the Litigation Hold only releases the mailbox if it was the only one.
2. **Remove the hold.** "This removes Litigation Hold from (person). Continue?" On yes, two commands: one removes the hold, one clears the tag so the mailbox stops appearing in the cleanup's confirmation report.
3. **Verify.** Good looks like LitigationHoldEnabled = False and an empty tag. A value called DelayHoldApplied = True is normal for about 30 days and is not a failure.
4. **The temporary licence.** If the cleanup gave the person a temporary E3 seat purely to enable the hold, it is theirs to keep or hand back through normal licensing - **the assistant will not print a licence-removal command.** If any hold remained at the previous step, the licence must stay.
5. **Ticket note:** before and after hold state, then close - the assistant asks first.

Path 2 - Copy a preserved mailbox into a shared mailbox (non-destructive)

The right answer to "we need their old email". The preserved mailbox stays exactly as it is.

1. **Find the preserved mailbox** and record its ExchangeGuid. Good looks like exactly one row, still on hold. If it also has an online archive, that is copied separately at step 3.
2. **Create the shared mailbox.** The assistant asks who needs access and what to call it (for example Archive - First Last). A shared mailbox under 50 GB needs no licence.
3. **Start the copy.** "This copies (N) items into the shared mailbox. The preserved mailbox is untouched. Continue?" The mail lands in its own folder inside the shared mailbox, not mixed into the Inbox. If the preserved mailbox also had an online archive, it is copied as a second request into another folder of the same shared mailbox (a new shared mailbox has no archive); only if the two together would exceed 50 GB does the shared mailbox get its own licensed archive - the assistant checks the sizes first.
4. **Watch it finish.** A large mailbox takes hours; InProgress is not a failure. Good looks like Status = Completed, 100 percent.
5. **Give the manager access** to the shared mailbox. It is deliberately not auto-added to their Outlook (a large archive would slow it down); the assistant prints the two-line instruction they follow to add it themselves.
6. **Confirm the preserved mailbox is still on hold** and tidy up the finished copy request. Good looks like: the manager can read the mail **and** the preserved mailbox still shows the hold. Ticket note; the assistant asks before closing.

Path 3 - A returning employee - and why it is usually NOT a recovery

Recovering the preserved mailbox itself turns it back into that person's live mailbox, and the preserved copy ceases to exist along with its hold. Microsoft only allows it when **both** are true: the account was deleted **more than 30 days ago**, and the person will be a **cloud-only** account. Most accounts here come from the on-premises directory, so most returning employees do not take this route.

1. **Check the two conditions** - the assistant already read them at step 0. Deleted less than 30 days ago: this is path 4 (restore the account), whatever the request said. Auto-expanding archive: stop - see step 0.
2. **Ask where the returning person's account will live.** If the answer is the on-premises directory - the usual answer here - **this is not a recovery.** The person is created on-premises, the sync is run on **AWSPRDINFAAD01** (Remote

Desktop, the same blue Windows PowerShell window there, two lines: **Import-Module ADSync** and **Start-ADSyncSyncCycle -PolicyType Delta**, then come back), a licence is assigned and a new, empty mailbox appears. Then **path 2** copies the old mail into it. The preserved copy survives, still on hold - the better outcome anyway. The decision goes on the ticket.

3. **Cloud-only, more than 30 days: the real recovery.** The assistant first confirms no account with that email address exists any more - the recovery creates the account, and it fails if one is already there.
4. **The gate.** The assistant tells you that the preserved copy will cease to exist and the hold with it, and that path 2 is still available right now. To proceed you must type exactly **RECOVER 1**. To switch to path 2 instead, type **PATH 2**. Anything else stops, and nothing has changed. You then set a first password for the returning person, which they must change at sign-in.
5. **Assign a licence** through normal licensing (the assistant does not do this), then verify: a normal mailbox exists for the person and the inactive list no longer contains them. Ticket note: who typed the phrase and when, the directory decision, the result.

Path 4 - Undelete an account deleted by mistake (30-day window)

A deleted account sits in a recycle bin for 30 days; a mailbox that lost its licence is likewise recoverable for 30 days. After that both are purged with no way back. **The assistant tells you the number of days left in its first reply**, and if it is under three days it does the recovery before it does the ticket.

1. **How long do you have?** The assistant reads the deletion date and tells you DaysLeft.
2. **Find the account in the recycle bin.** If the mailbox is soft-deleted but the account is not in the bin, the account was probably de-licensed rather than deleted - re-licensing it brings the mailbox back, and step 3 is skipped.
3. **Restore the account.** "This restores the account (address). It can be deleted again if needed. Continue?" If the account was on-premises, it must be restored on-premises as well and synced, or the next sync deletes it again.
4. **Re-license, then verify the mailbox came back.** This is not instant - allow hours. If it has not reattached by the time you finish, the report says so plainly rather than assuming it will.
5. **Ticket note:** days left at the start, what was restored, the licence, and what is and is not yet verified.

Path 5 - Permanent destruction of a preserved mailbox (retention ended) - IRREVERSIBLE

No undo, and no Microsoft support path. Only for a **preserved (inactive) mailbox** - a hold on a live mailbox is path 1. Only with written authorisation, only once the retention obligation has genuinely ended, and only after the authorisation reference is on the ticket (or in the closing report if ticketing is unreachable).

1. **Which mailbox, exactly?** The assistant looks the address up twice - once for a live mailbox, once for the preserved one - shows you both, and reads out the preserved mailbox's identifier (its ExchangeGuid) and deletion date. That identifier, never the email address, is what every later command in this path is aimed at.
2. **It may refuse here, and this is why.** If a live mailbox now has the same email address - the address was given to someone else after the leaver left - then "destroy the mailbox at this address" is ambiguous, and acting on the address alone could destroy the wrong person's mail. The assistant continues only if the written authorisation names the preserved mailbox's ExchangeGuid itself; if it names only the address, the path stops until the authorisation is corrected. If it does, the live mailbox is not touched.
3. **Confirm every hold, not just the Litigation Hold.** Exchange only purges once the **last** hold is gone. If a retention policy or an eDiscovery case still holds the mailbox, removing the Litigation Hold changes nothing - that is a

safety feature. If items carry a retention label, Microsoft does not allow the hold to be removed at all, and the path ends here. The assistant stops and tells you which hold remains and who owns its release.

4. **The gate.** The assistant states the authorisation reference, the retention schedule, the result of the identity check, and that once the delay hold clears the mailbox and every item in it are gone. To proceed you must type exactly **DESTROY 1**. Anything else stops, and nothing has changed.
5. **Clear the delay hold.** After the last hold is removed, Microsoft keeps the content for about 30 more days as a safety margin. If genuine destruction is the intent, the assistant reads which delay holds are set and clears only those. This needs a specific Exchange role (Legal Hold); an access-denied here means that role, not a wrong mailbox.
6. **Confirm and record.** The mailbox should now show as no longer preserved, with a retire date about 30 days out; if it still shows as preserved, a hold remains - back to the hold check. Every mailbox still on hold is exported to C:\scripts\reports\LitigationHold-AfterRemoval-(time).csv; keep it with the written authorisation. Ticket note: the reference, the identity check, who typed the phrase and when, the hold check, the file path.

Where the files are

- **C:\scripts\reports** - the preflight report and the exports you attach to the ticket.
- **C:\scripts\logs** - the detailed log and result file from the mailbox check at step 0 and any later check, named after the check and the time it ran.
- Both folders are created for you the first time they are needed. There is nothing else to find: every command you paste arrives complete.

When something goes wrong

1. **Stop.** Do not press Enter again and do not re-run the command.
2. **Copy the red text exactly** as it appears and paste it to the assistant. It needs the exact wording.
3. **Attach the report** from C:\scripts\reports and the matching log from C:\scripts\logs to the ServiceDesk Plus ticket.
4. **Things that look like failures and are not:** a copy request InProgress for hours on a large mailbox; DelayHoldApplied = True for a month after a hold is removed; a mailbox not reattaching for hours after an account is restored.

On path 4 the clock does not stop for a failure. If something breaks with only days left, say so to the assistant straight away.

Need help?

Anything the assistant cannot fix - a missing role, a hold owned by someone else, a mailbox that does not appear after several hours - goes to the Exchange administrator or Global Administrator through the ServiceDesk Plus ticket, with the report attached.